

WOMEN AT WORK: Afghan women receiving training in Ahmedabad



Helpline to Kabul

An Indian vocational training centre is enabling the women in Afghanistan to become self-reliant

■ **By Nandini Vaish**

Having transformed the lives of many women artisans at home, the Self-employed Women's Association (SEWA) is now setting up a vocational training centre for women in Afghanistan, at Bagh-e-Zanana (women's market), Kabul.

Currently, 35 Afghan women are training in Ahmedabad. The cost of the equipment, training fee and stipend in the first year, amounting to Rs 5.5 crore, will be borne by the Indian government, besides the building cost of the centre—\$0.6 million (Rs 2.6 crore). The courses will last about three months, with the fee ranging from Rs 12,000 to Rs 15,000 each.

Women are learning embroidery, weaving, tailoring, food processing, packaging, design and product development, environmental regeneration and upgradation of marketing and managements skills. Some in shorter courses have already gone back to teach the others. "For the first time in the country's recent history, women are learning to express their experiences of growing up in the war-torn country. It is a quiet revolution," says Reema Nanavaty, director, Economic and Rural Development, SEWA, who is heading the project, which was inaugurated by Gurusharan Kaur, the wife of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, during her visit in August 2005.



As part of food processing, the women at the Kabul centre are being trained in preservation and packaging of fruits for domestic use and export. Afghanistan's fruits and nuts have a market in India and the women, says Nanavaty, can train small and marginal farmers to package their products better for export purposes. Soon, market access and linkages will be provided for the women to enhance job security.

According to Afghanistan's Ministry of the Women's Affairs, there are about 1.5 million widows, mostly illiterate, in 26 districts in Kabul. The ill-effects of the war are evident in the country, where 12 million women are living in abject poverty. A research by the Revolutionary Association of the Women of Afghanistan shows 25,000 women had to work as prostitutes in 2001. Now, over 2,500 women have registered with the ministry to obtain proper jobs.

Since 2002, India has been playing a significant role in the reconstruction of the country, having spent \$758 million (Rs 3,200 crore) till now. The training centre is one of the many projects India will undertake, including hydro-electricity, power transmission lines, road construction, agriculture and industry, telecommunications and education and health. SEWA aims to train about 1,000 women within the first year. A small step towards big achievement.